



## BRAND GUIDELINES

# SmartScholar

Turning a scholarship deadline into a route a student can actually walk.

## An S drawn as a road

Lane dashes down the middle, a start node bottom-left, a waypoint in the belly, a gold destination top-right.



It works because it isn't a metaphor bolted onto a letter — **the letter is the route**. That's the product in one shape: a deadline becomes a path with steps on it, and the last step is arrival rather than another search result.

**Why not a graduation cap.** Every scholarship site uses one, which makes you look like the category rather than a specific thing inside it. A cap also fails the practical tests below — it turns to mush at favicon size and has no natural motion.

### What the mark has to survive

| TEST                          | WHY IT MATTERS                                     |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Legible at 16px</b>        | The browser tab is where people mostly see it      |
| <b>Works in one colour</b>    | Print, embroidery, WhatsApp avatars                |
| <b>Reversed on dark</b>       | Half the app is dark mode                          |
| <b>No gradient dependency</b> | Gradients die in email clients and favicons        |
| <b>Animatable</b>             | The road can draw itself — used in the launch film |

## Six files, one source

Everything is generated by `node scripts/build-brand.mjs` from `logo-source.svg`. Never hand-edit an output.



app-icon.svg



app-icon-dark.svg



logo-mark.svg



favicon.svg

**Two viewBoxes, deliberately.** The artwork has heavy padding — the road occupies under half the canvas. That's correct inside an app-icon tile, where the OS expects margin, and badly wrong everywhere else: at 16px it leaves about seven real pixels of mark. Icons keep the full canvas; everything else crops tight.

**The favicon drops the lane dashes.** At 16px each dash is under a pixel wide and they grey the road into mud. The road, the nodes and the gold destination survive. That's a detail budget, not a second logo.

### Rules

|                     |                                                             |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Clear space</b>  | Equal to the diameter of the gold node, on every side       |
| <b>Minimum size</b> | 16px. Below that, use nothing at all                        |
| <b>On dark</b>      | White road, gold node kept. Gold never changes              |
| <b>In the app</b>   | Compose the mark with live text — don't use the lockup file |

### Never

Recolour the road · drop the gold node · add a gradient · rotate the mark · stretch it · place it inside any shape other than the app-icon tile · set the wordmark in a face other than the brand font.

# Navy is the voice. Gold is the reward.

Both come straight out of the logo. Everything else exists to support them.

Navy — structure, text, buttons

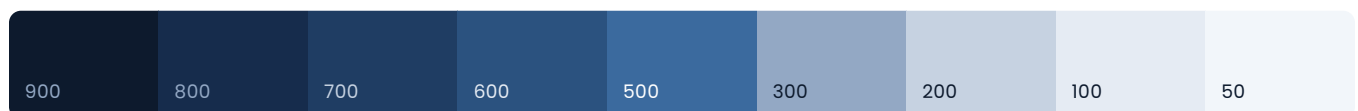
**#162C4C**

Gold — arrival, and only arrival

**#C6A14B**

**Gold is rationed.** It appears when a student arrives at something — verified, eligible, matched, step completed. That's what the gold node means in the mark. Spray it everywhere and it stops meaning arrival, which is exactly how the previous teal system died.

## Navy



Links and interactive text use **500 • #3B6A9E** — 5.2:1 on white. The logo navy itself is too dark to read as a link.

## Gold



**Never set body text in #C6A14B.** It's 2.1:1 on white — a contrast failure at every size. Use **700 • #8A6E2C** on light and **200 • #EDE0BE** on dark.

## Neutrals — warm, not grey



Cold greys fight gold and make navy look like a corporate default. A paper-white ground makes both look chosen.

## Four meanings, four colours

Muted deliberately. Bright semantic colours on a navy-and-gold ground look like error dialogs, and this product should feel calm about a stressful thing.

### ● eligible

You qualify · verified · step done

#2E7D62

### ● urgent

Deadline close · act soon

#BF6B3A

### ● blocked

Not eligible · expired · broken

#A8443A

### ● unknown

The source didn't say

#6B7387

### The most important rule in this document: "unknown" is its own colour.

The entire trust proposition is admitting what a source didn't state. Most platforms fold that into a warning colour, or worse into the success colour, and imply the student qualifies when nobody said so.

A distinct, deliberately unexciting slate — always with a **dashed** border, never solid — says *we don't know* without saying *be alarmed*.

It is **not** amber. Amber sits next to gold, and gold means arrival. Two meanings competing for one hue is how a palette stops communicating.

## Dark mode

Card

**#14263F**

Gold is the constant

**#C6A14B**

Ground #0D1A2D · surface #14263F · line #22374F · text #E8EEF6 . Gold does not shift between modes.

# IBM Plex Sans + IBM Plex Sans Arabic

One superfamily, drawn together, metrically harmonised.

This is the **fourth** Arabic font this project has tried. The previous three failed for the same reason: the Arabic and Latin faces were chosen separately, so they never sat on a line properly. Plex removes the problem — they're one design. It suits the mark too: engineered rather than friendly, quietly serious, calm over long reading. A geometric face reads consumer-app where this brand needs **dependable**.

Latin · 600

## Stop searching. Start applying.

Arabic · 400 · line-height 1.8

المشكلة ليست أنك لا تجد المنح — المشكلة أنك تبدأ متأخراً.

### Scale — only these sizes

| TOKEN   | PIXEL DESKTOP / MOBILE | WEIGHT | USE               |
|---------|------------------------|--------|-------------------|
| display | 56 / 38                | 600    | Landing hero only |
| h1      | 36 / 28                | 600    | Page title        |
| h2      | 28 / 23                | 600    | Section           |
| h3      | 20 / 18                | 600    | Card title        |
| body    | 16                     | 400    | Everything        |
| small   | 14                     | 400    | Secondary         |
| caption | 12                     | 500    | Labels, metadata  |

Headings at **600, not 700**. Plex at 700 is heavy enough to feel loud, and loud is the opposite of what this brand does.

**16px minimum on form inputs. Non-negotiable.** iOS Safari zooms the page on any focused control under 16px and never zooms back. That single bug made signup feel broken on iPhone for a week.

### Arabic

|                   |                                                          |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Line height 1.8   | vs 1.6 Latin. Tailwind's default crops descenders        |
| No uppercase      | It does nothing in Arabic and signals nobody checked     |
| No letter-spacing | It breaks the joins between letters                      |
| Isolate numerals  | Numbers, emails and URLs stay LTR: unicode-bidi: isolate |

# Rules, not measurements

## Spacing

Multiples of four only: 4 8 12 16 24 32 48 64 96 . Nothing else. Arbitrary values like p-[13px] are how a system rots.

## Radius

| TOKEN | PX  | USE                 |
|-------|-----|---------------------|
| sm    | 8   | Inputs, chips       |
| md    | 12  | Buttons, badges     |
| lg    | 16  | Cards               |
| xl    | 24  | Modals, hero panels |
| full  | 999 | Pills, avatars      |

The app-icon tile uses a 22.5% corner radius, matching the artwork. That ratio belongs to the icon — don't apply it elsewhere.

## Direction

**Logical properties only.** ms/me , ps/pe , start/end . Never ml/mr/pl/pr/left/right . The app is RTL-first and physical directions don't mirror — that's what put the input icons on top of the text in Arabic.

## Breakpoints

xs 400 · sm 640 · md 768 · lg 1024 · xl 1280 . **xs** exists because Tailwind's smallest default is 640px, which is a tablet — without it, 360–390px phones always got the most cramped layout.

## Elevation

Shadows are navy-tinted, never pure black. Black shadows on a warm paper ground look dirty.

|           |                                |
|-----------|--------------------------------|
| 1 • rest  | 0 1px 2px rgba(22,44,76,.08)   |
| 2 • hover | 0 6px 20px rgba(22,44,76,.10)  |
| 3 • modal | 0 20px 44px rgba(22,44,76,.16) |

Motion is specified on the next page.

# Things arrive; they don't appear

Position or scale plus a slight overshoot. A pure opacity fade is the clearest tell of a cheap interface.

| SPEED | DURATION | USE                         |
|-------|----------|-----------------------------|
| Fast  | 150ms    | Hover, focus, colour change |
| Base  | 250ms    | Cards, panels, most things  |
| Slow  | 400ms    | Page and modal transitions  |

Easing `cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)` for entrances, `ease-out` for exits. Entrances land softly; exits leave quickly.



The road draws itself, start node to gold destination

**The signature motion is the road drawing itself** — start node to gold destination, about 1.8 seconds, eased at both ends, with a travelling light at the build point and a gold ring on arrival.

Use it for the logo reveal and for anything representing a completed journey. **Never for loading.** It means *progress toward a goal*, not *please wait*, and spending it on a spinner burns the one piece of motion the brand owns.

Reference implementation: [video-assets/logo.py](#).

Respect `prefers-reduced-motion` — cut every duration to 0.01ms. Vestibular disorders are common and the road animation is exactly the kind of sustained movement that triggers them.



# Calm about something stressful

Arabic first. English is the translation, not the other way round.

| DO                   | DON'T                          |
|----------------------|--------------------------------|
| منحة بدون آيلتس      | فرص تعليمية متميزة             |
| خلال ١٩ يوماً        | قريباً                         |
| غير مذكور في المصدر  | أنت مؤهل (when nobody said so) |
| Helps you apply well | Gets you accepted              |

## The four rules

**Say what you don't know.** غير مذكور في المصدر is the most important string in the product. Every competitor implies eligibility it can't verify; not doing that is the whole brand.

**Numbers over adjectives.** "Nineteen days" tells a student what to do. "Soon" tells them to worry.

**Never promise an outcome.** You help people apply well. You don't get them accepted, and claiming otherwise is the fastest way to lose the trust the rest of this document is built on.

**The student is already anxious.** The interface must not be. No urgency theatre, no countdown drama, no red where slate will do.

## Positioning, in one paragraph

Students across the Arab world lose scholarships they qualified for — not because they miss deadlines, but because they start three weeks too late. Recommendation letters take six weeks. IELTS results take two. No listings site tells them that. SmartScholar turns any deadline into a dated plan and reminds you before every step.

# Making it real

The full token block lives in `BRAND-IDENTITY.md`, which is the machine-readable source of truth. This page is the order of work.

## Migration order

| # | STEP                                                                                       |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Paste the token block into <code>globals.css</code>                                        |
| 2 | Delete every teal, brand-deep, brand-mid and accent-warm token                             |
| 3 | Add <code>unknown</code> to <code>tailwind.config.ts</code>                                |
| 4 | Replace the S-in-a-box placeholder in <code>nav.tsx</code> with <code>logo-mark.svg</code> |
| 5 | Wire <code>favicon.svg</code> and the app icons into <code>layout.tsx</code>               |
| 6 | Load IBM Plex Sans + Sans Arabic; delete Majara and Poppins                                |
| 7 | Fix every <code>danger-50</code> / <code>success-200</code> class — see below              |
| 8 | Regenerate <code>og.png</code> ; sweep for off-scale spacing                               |

**Step 7 matters more than it sounds.** Numeric colour scales such as `danger-50` and `success-200` do not exist in the Tailwind config and never have. Every one of them renders as nothing — which is why the error boxes in the auth flow appeared unstyled for months. Use alpha modifiers instead: `bg-danger/10`, `border-danger/30`.

## Keeping it from drifting

This identity is the fourth attempt. The first three drifted because decisions lived in people's heads and in scattered CSS, and because the favicon, the app icon and the nav logo were three files edited separately.

Two safeguards now exist. **Every asset is generated** from one SVG by `scripts/build-brand.mjs`, so the geometry cannot diverge. And **BRAND-IDENTITY.md is authoritative**: if a value isn't in it, it doesn't exist. Change it there first, then in code.

**Colophon.** Generated by `scripts/build-brand-book.py` from the live brand assets. Typeset in Poppins because IBM Plex was not installed on the build machine — the brand face is Plex, as specified on page 5, and this document is the one place it isn't used. Arabic set in DejaVu Sans for the same reason.